

Southern Europe



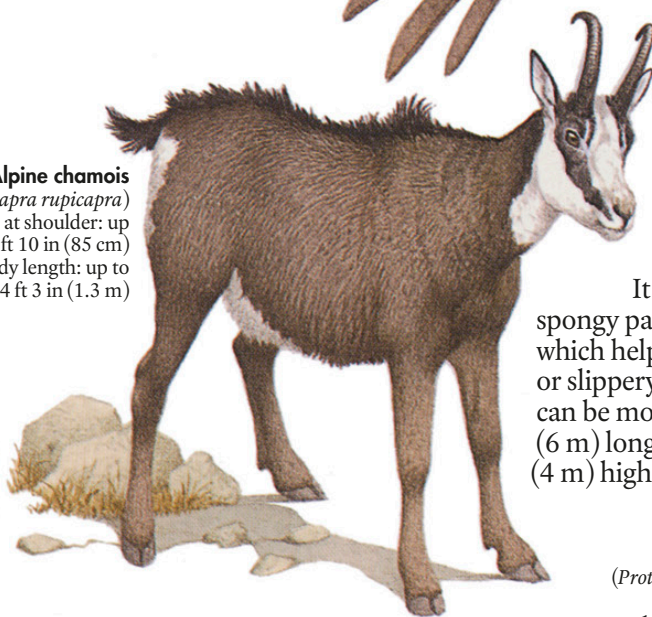
THE COUNTRIES OF SOUTHERN EUROPE lie around the northern coast of the Mediterranean Sea. They have a climate of long, hot, dry summers with cooler, wetter winters. The typical landscape of this region is dry scrubland. Large numbers of people live in southern Europe or go there on vacation.

People have destroyed most of the region's forests and polluted the sea, but there are still some refuges for wildlife, such as the Alps and Pyrenees mountains, the marshlands of the Coto Doñana in Spain, and the Camargue in France. Some rare animals, such as the chamois, live in these protected areas. Southern Europe is also famous for its birdlife. Huge numbers of birds fly across the region on their regular migration routes between Europe and Africa.

Brown bear (*Ursus arctos*)
Height at shoulder: up to 5 ft (1.5 m)
Body length: up to 9 ft 2 in (2.8 m)



Alpine chamois
(*Rupicapra rupicapra*)
Height at shoulder: up to 2 ft 10 in (85 cm)
Body length: up to 4 ft 3 in (1.3 m)

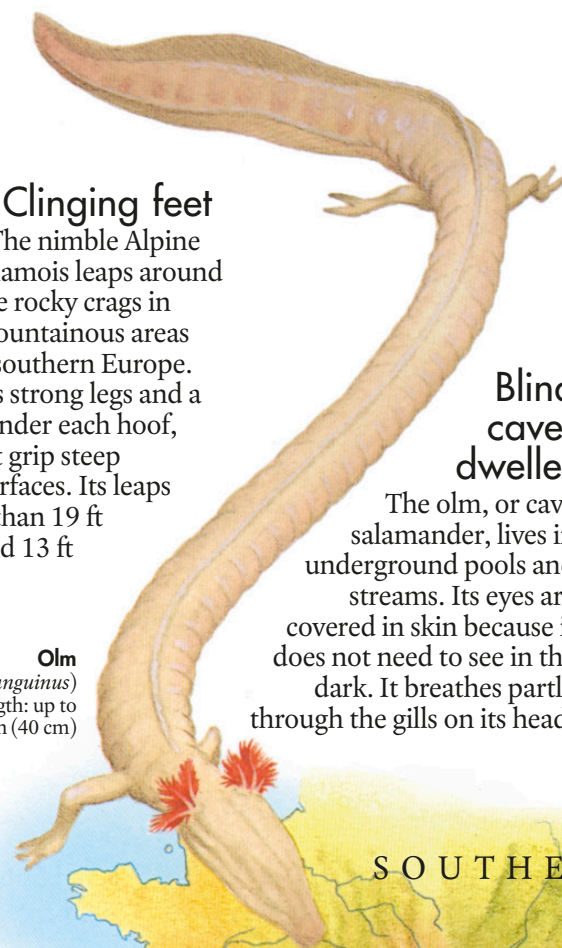


Clinging feet

The nimble Alpine chamois leaps around the rocky crags in mountainous areas of southern Europe.

It has strong legs and a spongy pad under each hoof, which helps it grip steep or slippery surfaces. Its leaps can be more than 19 ft (6 m) long and 13 ft (4 m) high.

Olm
(*Proteus anguinus*)
Length: up to 15.7 in (40 cm)



Blind cave-dweller

The olm, or cave salamander, lives in underground pools and streams. Its eyes are covered in skin because it does not need to see in the dark. It breathes partly through the gills on its head.

Name call

The hoopoe is named after its call, which sounds like "hoopoo-poo." Young hoopoes drive enemies away from their nest by producing a strong smell, hissing loudly, and poking their bills upward.

Common hoopoe
(*Upupa epops*)
Length: up to 12.6 in (32 cm)



Nearsighted bear

The brown bear is nearsighted, so it relies on its keen sense of smell to find food. It is mostly vegetarian, using its long claws to dig up roots, shoots, and bulbs. In the fall, the bear fattens up to prepare for its winter hibernation. It lives in the mountains of southern Europe.

Green toad (*Bufo viridis*)
Length: up to 4.7 in (12 cm)



Insect gobbler

The green toad comes out in the cool, moist night air to hunt for insects. It sometimes enters villages to hunt around street lamps and other sources of light that attract insects. The toad has no teeth and swallows its food whole.

Lammergeyer
(*Gypaetus barbatus*)
Length: up to 4 ft 1 in (1.25 m)
Wingspan: up to 9 ft 3 in (2.8 m)



Bone breaker

The lammergeyer, or bearded vulture, feeds on bones that it scavenges from dead animals. Before it starts to feed, it waits until other vultures have pecked all the meat off the bones. The lammergeyer sometimes drops bones from a great height so that they crack open. It can then eat the marrow inside.



The typical Mediterranean habitat consists of dry scrubland covered with thorny shrubs and small trees.